The Communist Effect: The Creation of Eastern Europe

Not only in Eastern Europe, but in another part of the European periphery, in Portugal and Spain and then soon in Greece too, authoritarian systems continued after World War II. In fact, there are some interesting parallels between Eastern Europe and other fringes of Europe. As the authors of a book with a suggestive title 'Peripheral Identities' conclude, 'Portugal, Spain and the Eastern European countries experienced long-lasting totalitarian regimes and only turned to Europe after the collapse of their respective dictatorships.'[75] In the case of Spain, the memoires of Leopoldo Calvo-Sotelo, one of the leading figures of Spain's accession to the European Union, attest that the process of *transición* and rapprochement to Europe was equally marked by internal discussion of both Europeanising of Spain and Spain's contribution to European identity.[76]

Moreover, even 'the creation of identity in all of these countries is strongly influenced by their long experience of dictatorships during the last century and also by the European integration'. The authors, however, observe an important difference in 'the fact that the revolution in Portugal and the democratic transition in Spain came about themselves, whereas in Poland, the Czech Republic and Romania the advent of democracy was also the advent of political sovereignty.' They conclude that the construction of national identity in Eastern Europe was more influenced by disassociation (from the Soviet Union or Yugoslavia) and at the same time by the idea of Europe, which is seen as a disassociation from the East. In their view too, Eastern Europe 'become a more ideologically based term' than the term Iberia, which is largely geographic.

Theirs could have very well been the fate for Eastern Europe after World War II, but history travelled down a different path. At the end of the war, generously helped by the presence of Soviet troops, Communist parties came into power in all the countries behind the Iron Curtain, thus consummating the agreement on spheres of interest between the great powers, and effectively creating what we have known ever since as Eastern Europe. Sometimes this happened through (more or less manipulated)